

Neighborhood Business Grant Sample Application:
Narrative Response Examples

In at least 150 words provide a detailed project description. Tell us what your project is. Explain what is going to be done beyond what you do in your everyday business operations.

Since LES Fitness empowers formerly incarcerated individuals through fitness and employment opportunities, our core project involves visits to facilities like Rikers Island and juvenile detention centers. There we will teach incarcerated individuals the skills needed to become certified group fitness instructors. By providing professional training that opens career pathways upon release, we aim to transform lives through fitness, while simultaneously promoting physical and mental well-being for those facing the challenges of reentry. At LES Fitness, we believe that everyone deserves a second chance, and we are dedicated to creating pathways for sustainable success.

Beyond providing employment opportunities, LES Fitness wants to support formerly incarcerated people by connecting them with a community once their sentences are complete. We are firm believers that the best way to feel connected to the community you reside or work in is to get involved in neighborhood efforts to impact it in a positive way. We want people connected with LES Fitness to give back and be exposed to the various ways that they can support others. In our neighborhood in the Lower East side, we plan to organize various drives that will give away coats, turkeys, and toys, which will connect our LES Fitness workers and clients with people who are in need. We also want to organize community cleanups in order to inspire our workers and clients to be better invested in their blocks and their cleanliness. We hope through these efforts that we can create a collaborative environment between LES Fitness and the Lower East Side.

Together, these two aspects of our project will create an example for how to meaningfully support those who are incarcerated and their transition back to their communities. While we provide services to them, we also show them that they have value to provide to others.

In at least 150 words why is the project needed in your community? What does a successful project look like?

LES Fitness serves a crucial purpose in society as it directly addresses the significant challenges faced by formerly incarcerated individuals when reentering the community. These individuals often struggle with barriers such as limited job opportunities due to their criminal record or lack of employable skills, leading to financial instability and a cycle of hopelessness that can result in recidivism.

At LES Fitness, we aim to break this cycle by providing training and certification in group fitness instruction, creating employment pathways for our participants, and fostering a

sense of community within our program. We strongly believe that having a steady job with a living wage and a supportive network is vital for long-term success after incarceration. By empowering individuals through fitness and professional development, we are not only reducing recidivism rates but also supporting positive reintegration into society. We understand the importance of a second chance and strive to provide our participants with the necessary tools and support to help them succeed in their journey towards a better future. By offering opportunities for growth and personal development, LES Fitness is making a positive impact on the lives of formerly incarcerated individuals and promoting a more inclusive community.

In at least 150 words how will your business use this project to strengthen relationships among community members and project participants? How will your business conduct outreach to the community in support of your project?

Providing job training and connection to community to formerly incarcerated individuals is crucial for their reintegration and benefits the neighborhoods they return to. After leaving prison, many face feelings of isolation due to their past. A supportive community bridges the gap by offering acceptance and understanding, fostering emotional stability and personal growth. With some guidance, access to resources, and mentorship, individuals are more likely to engage positively, reducing the chances of recidivism. By helping them rebuild their lives, we strengthen our neighborhoods as they become active, productive members who contribute to the community's social and economic fabric. LES Fitness' success is not just measured by the number of individuals we help secure employment for, but also by the strong, supportive network we create. Our goal is to empower individuals to break free from the cycle of incarceration and serve as role models for others facing similar challenges, ultimately enhancing the overall well-being of our communities.

In at least 150 words how will the project be sustained after the grant period?

Our work will be sustained beyond the grant period through the strong community we have built at LES Fitness. We will continue to foster relationships within prisons and at our facility, encouraging formerly incarcerated individuals to form bonds with others who share similar experiences. This network of support will empower participants to give back and uplift their communities, creating a ripple effect that disrupts the cycle of recidivism and promotes successful reintegration. Through strong partnerships with organizations and businesses, we will provide ongoing job opportunities and resources to ensure their continued success long after they leave LES Fitness. We will also advocate for criminal justice reform and raise awareness about the barriers faced by returning citizens to drive positive change in our communities. With determination and a commitment to lasting impact, we believe LES Fitness can positively transform the lives of those who have been marginalized and help them rebuild a brighter future.